ENTERTAINMENT

The Fugitive from Oz

When *Shantaram* premieres on Apple TV+ this month, audiences must not expect a "slavish recreation" of Gregory David Roberts' bestselling novel

It's '80s Bombay; the city is still nearly a decade away from reclaiming its putative, pre-colonial identity of Mumbai, and its lanes are bathed in the honey hues characteristic of a vintage Bollywood, whose shadows hide the equally enigmatic underworld. The unmatched seduction of this classic mise en scène continues to capture popular imagination like few others, and the latest to have exploited it are the makers of the Apple TV+ original series *Shantaram*, a show that comes nearly two decades after the publication of its bestselling source novel, written by Australian author Gregory David Roberts.

Premiering worldwide on October 14, the series follows Lindsay "Lin" Ford, an Australian fugitive charged with bank robbery and heroin addiction—much like the author himself—whose escape to "the pits", a.k.a. Bombay, leads him to encounters and misadventures that take him closer to his freedom, the literal and metaphorical kind. While the 900-odd-pages-long book deep-dives into the whizz-bang odyssey undertaken by the protagonist, the series aims to live up to its formidable reputation by riding on the able shoulders of the lead played by British actor Charlie Hunnam, who makes his comeback after eight years.

Despite being an adaptation, the on-screen rendition of the story is not a "slavish recreation of the book", showrunner and executive producer Steve Lightfoot tells INDIA TODAY. He calls Roberts "incredibly generous" with his time and understanding of the medium, as he was "happy to let [us] make it [our] own thing". After two decades of news and rumours about *Shantaram* being made into a film have done the rounds almost like clockwork, the fact that it finally landed with Lightfoot gave it the destiny it truly deserved. "A lot of the problems before this was because people were trying to make it as a feature film, and it's just impossible to fit everything that's in that book into two or three hours. I had the benefit of being really able to take my time and get on to the surface of the book in a way that a shorter form wouldn't have allowed," he says.

The 12-part series, which clocks in an average runtime of an hour per episode, hopes to capture the protagonist's fantastical, often outlandish journey through the Indian landscape veritably, and without falling prey to the western gaze or orientalist cliches. According to Lightfoot, such issues of representation could only be circumvented by having enough of it. "There were two Indian writers on the show; our director Bharat Nalluri was born in India, and is obviously of Indian descent. It was just about trying to ensure that there were enough points of view in the team so we could make sure we were as authentic as possible," the showrunner says about this story of hope, or what its fans held onto for nearly 20 years to see it finally come alive on screen. ■

Arshia

The series doesn't fall prey to the white man's gaze that is notorious for pandering to cliches of famine porn

